Primetime's Questions Are More Interesting Than Its Answers

On "To Catch a Predator," moral motives, and what happens when public service becomes entertainment.

Henry Metz · September 2026 · Independent Essay

This essay began as a review of Lance Oppenheim's Primetime *before expanding into a broader examination of the ethical questions surrounding* To Catch a Predator. *An edited version was subsequently published in* 34th Street Magazine. *This expanded version explores questions of moral responsibility, deterrence, and the tension between public service and entertainment in greater depth.*
Read the published review in 34th Street Magazine

I. THE MORE INTERESTING MOVIE

Does doing the right thing for the wrong reasons make that "thing" any less right? That is the main question rattling around my head when discussing *To Catch a Predator*, Chris Hansen's television show whose sole premise is luring potential child predators into decoy houses and siccing the police on them. And Lance Oppenheim's *Primetime*, a dramatization of specific events surrounding the show, seems similarly fascinated by that question. Unfortunately, it's far more interested in just raising it than truly wrestling with it.

The film lives in the increasingly blurry line between journalism, public service, and entertainment behind it. On one level, the moral math seems pretty simple: adults attempt to meet children for sex, they are caught, would-be (and sometimes actual, former) predators are exposed, and people who might otherwise hurt children face consequences. Whatever else you think about the show that facilitated those outcomes, it's difficult to argue that preventing sexual abuse is anything but good.

Then comes Robert Pattinson's Chris Hansen. Personally, I don't take anything in the movie as evidence of the actual Hansen's private motivations or moral character, but the character Pattinson creates is captivating in every sense of the word. He's ambitious, charismatic, self-assured, and just slippery enough that you're never entirely sure whether his crusade against sexual predators is driven by moral conviction, professional ambition, or some inseparable combination of the two.

Put simply, Pattinson is impossible to look away from—I could watch hours of this character just talking with everyone around him. The less villainous he is, the more compelling he becomes. Combined with the film's unnerving visual aesthetic and often claustrophobic directorial choices, *Primetime* turns a straightforward Wikipedia summary into something genuinely tense. Whatever issues I have with the movie, boredom isn't one of them; I was entertained for the entire runtime.

The problem is that *Primetime* keeps introducing more interesting movies than the one it ultimately is. The more interesting version of the film might begin with a Hansen who genuinely believes every

word of his crusade. When he tells a decoy that they are fighting an "ancient evil," does he mean it? Did he begin *To Catch a Predator* because he wanted to protect children, because he wanted to make great TV, or—as seems infinitely more human—because he wanted both? And what happens when the ratings start coming in and those motivations become impossible to separate? *Primetime* never really lets us watch that transformation; Hansen instead begins the movie already slippery enough that his supposed moral deterioration has nowhere particularly interesting to go. Worse, he increasingly takes a backseat in his own story.

In his place, the movie takes small bites out of several other ideas without ever fully digging into one. We briefly see the mental toll the operation takes on the decoys tasked with pretending to be children and engaging predators in disturbing conversations. That idea is interesting: what does spending hours inhabiting that world, seeing these people face-to-face, do to someone? But the movie only gets so far into it before moving elsewhere.

The show's producer similarly embodies the production's growing moral unease, but her allegiance fluctuates too conveniently. At different points, she's complicit, disturbed, ambitious, frustrated when Hansen goes over her head, and then seemingly fully on board, all without her final decision feeling earned. Rather than watching someone gradually realize she's crossed a line, we watch her relationship with that line change according to what the scene needs.

Then there's Hansen's cheating subplot, which feels particularly forced because it gives the audience such an easy, tangible reason to dislike him. Infidelity makes the moral conflict simpler because suddenly, there's 'hard evidence' that this version of Hansen is not a particularly good guy. It feels like the movie is spelling out to us that, even if we sympathize with Hansen's cause, we shouldn't sympathize too much with Hansen himself; giving us such an easy reason to condemn him only removes nuance.

But why does Hansen's moral character matter in the first place? If he catches someone attempting to sexually exploit a child, does it matter whether he did so because he wanted to protect children or because he wanted 10 million people watching NBC? And why should his cheating on his wife change our answer?

II. THE RIGHT THING FOR THE WRONG REASONS

For me, it largely doesn't. If an action produces a genuine net positive for the world, discovering that the person responsible had selfish motivations or was otherwise deeply flawed doesn't suddenly erase that good. If someone donates millions of dollars to charity just because they want good press, I may cringe a little, but the recipients of that donation are no less helped than if that person were a genuine saint. Intent matters when judging a person, and consequences matter when judging what they did. The two are not mutually exclusive.

Of course, *To Catch a Predator* complicates that distinction because its criticism has never solely been about Hansen's intentions. Even if we accept catching potential sexual predators as an obvious good, that doesn't automatically justify every method used to accomplish it. The spectacle, humiliation, incentives created by ratings, psychological effects on those participating, and transformation of criminal behavior into entertainment all deserve scrutiny. There truly is a meaningful difference between asking "Did something good happen" and "Was this a good way to make it happen?"

The ethical questions become especially uncomfortable when participants appear particularly vulnerable, raising additional concerns about the morality of turning them into television spectacle. Public humiliation doesn't treat whatever psychological problems contributed to their behavior. It doesn't necessarily make their underlying urges disappear. At most, you could argue that the threat of being caught and publicly exposed might deter someone from acting on them, and I am sympathetic to that argument. Deterrence doesn't require changing what someone thinks—sometimes, changing what they're willing to do is enough.

Would it be better to identify these individuals, intervene before anyone is harmed, and offer treatment where appropriate instead of tackling them? Probably. But that exposes another uncomfortable reality: Hansen's operation only exists because it makes television people want to watch. Perhaps treatment would produce a better long-term outcome, but it probably wouldn't produce NBC ratings. And without those ratings, Hansen loses the money and resources that allow his operation to exist in the first place. The show therefore has to exist at the intersection of two separate standards: it has to be socially useful enough to justify itself yet entertaining enough to remain on television.

But I don't think *Primetime* spends enough time untangling that conflict. Instead, the questionable motives and questionable methods begin bleeding together until the movie's discomfort with the entire enterprise becomes clearer than what it actually wants to say about it.

And there is a compelling argument on the other side of mine—maybe the motivations behind *To Catch a Predator* cannot be separated from what the show became. If executives are rewarded every time an encounter becomes more shocking, then "catching predators" and "making entertaining television" are no longer independent goals. The latter can begin shaping how the former is accomplished. A public service built around ratings has an incentive not merely to expose wrongdoing, but to make that wrongdoing as entertaining as possible.

That's fascinating. I sure would've liked *Primetime* to make me wrestle with it more.

And yes, there can absolutely be value in a movie that asks questions without answering them for its audience. I don't necessarily need *Primetime* to explicitly tell me whether *To Catch a Predator* was good or bad or whether Hansen's methods were justified, but if you already know the show and the events the movie dramatizes, you're not given much that you couldn't have already asked yourself beforehand. These questions aren't discoveries the film creates, they're questions already embedded in the story it chose to tell. If the movie isn't going to answer them, I at least want it to complicate them—to leave me thinking about *To Catch a Predator* differently than I did when I walked in. Instead, I mostly walked out asking the same questions I already had.

III. WHEN PREVENTION BECOMES PUNISHMENT

My frustration comes to a head in the film's climax. The nail in the coffin for *To Catch a Predator* comes when a district attorney dies by suicide as a sting closes in on him. It's a horrifying outcome, and one that effectively brings the whole show crashing down. But it also raises a question that may sound monstrous to even ask: How are we supposed to morally evaluate what happened?

I don't think there is a correct answer here. Suicide is tragic, and taking a life is so morally fraught that we continue to debate whether the state should ever be allowed to do it. At the same time, the entire premise of *To Catch a Predator* is that stopping adults from sexually exploiting children makes

the world safer. So if an operation intended to prevent that behavior accidentally contributes to someone's death, does that automatically make the operation inherently wrong? Does it matter that there was never a trial? Does it matter what harm might have been prevented? At what point does preventing harm turn into inflicting it? I'm not asking those questions rhetorically, because I really don't have my own satisfying answers to them.

It becomes even more difficult to answer because, at the time of the sting, the district attorney had not been convicted of the conduct for which he was being pursued. He didn't even go to the decoy house—he was ambushed in his own home. But the simple truth is that we can never know what he would or wouldn't have done afterward. If you believe punishment can only follow a proven offense, the outcome is especially appalling. If you place greater moral weight on nipping a potential issue in the bud before it ever sprouts, your conclusion may be different, but hardly easy. I genuinely don't know where I land, and I think that uncertainty is worth sitting with.

All of that is precisely what makes this one incident so interesting—it contains nearly every question *Primetime* is already asking about punishment, exploitation, public good, personal responsibility, and the consequences of turning justice into entertainment. I completely understand why someone would see all of this and make a movie out of it. Yet, like so many of its ideas, the movie moves on—there's only one scene left afterward. And that's ultimately my main issue with the film: it juggles so much that it inevitably drops a few things along the way. I would have traded some of that breadth for an intense focus and unflinching exploration of even just one of these moral questions.

And so I kept thinking about what the movie could have been. If it wanted to be a character study, show me Hansen at the beginning. Let me watch his original combination of conviction and ambition slowly become warped by success. Make me wonder precisely when the mission stopped being the point and the show became a product—or whether there was ever a distinction to begin with.

If it wanted to interrogate the production itself, spend more time with the decoys, producers, cameras, and compromises behind the scenes. I'd like to see how a journalistic operation gradually hones the rhythms of entertainment and how everyone involved rationalizes the next crazy escalation.

And if it wanted to interrogate the ethics of *To Catch a Predator*, then really interrogate them. Let people vehemently disagree with one another and acknowledge that something can be exploitative yet simultaneously socially useful. Take that horrifying final sting and force us to really sit with everything it complicates. Make the audience walk out arguing over what the right answer even was.

Somewhere inside *Primetime* are these three movies, all of which I desperately want to watch. I'd happily turn on a detailed behind-the-scenes drama about how *To Catch a Predator* became *To Catch a Predator*. I'd also watch two philosophers sit in a room for two hours arguing about whether a show built on humiliation, spectacle, and questionable motives can still make the world meaningfully better. *Primetime* tries to be all of them at once, but I left wishing it had fully committed to any one of them.

But again, that frustration should not be confused with disinterest. I never checked my watch, Pattinson is undeniably magnetic, and the filmmaking brings a visual and psychological intensity that most biopics would kill for. I just walked out more interested in talking about the questions surrounding *To Catch a Predator* than anything *Primetime* itself had to say about them.